

PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

POST-RETURN MOROCCO

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Name of practice	National Strategy for Immigration and Asylum	
Dates	2014-2023/2024	
Target group	Moroccan returnees, foreign migrants regularised	
Geographic Scope	Country	Morocco
	Regions	Africa
	Sub Region	North Africa
Actor	National Government, Local-Authorities International and local NGOs	
Return Stages	Post-Return	
Challenge addressed	Reintegration Sustainability	
Principles referred (implicit or explicit)	Migrants' Agency Human-rights-based approach	

SUMMARY

The 2014 National Immigration and Asylum Strategy (NIAS – SNIA, in French) represents the first comprehensive, rights-based migration framework in the MENA–African region. It combined asylum reform, large-scale regularisation campaigns, and structured access to public services, including health, education,

The strategy, aimed at stabilising regular migration flows, regularise migrants' status, reduce the number of people living without legal residency, curb human trafficking and smuggling networks, and reposition Morocco's image in Africa.

The NIAS was operationalised through a set of thematic programmes, often cited as 11 priority domains, covering health, education, housing, legal protection, labour, governance, and cooperation. Implementation has been staged via national action plans and ad hoc measures. Key steps included two major regularisation campaigns (2014 and 2017) and subsequent action plans (e.g., 2018–2020 and 2021–2023), translating SNIA goals into concrete measures.

While the NIAS can be considered a “good practice,” this assessment is conditional and dependent on the context of Moroccan-European relations at the time, and the strategy is better understood as a promising, norm-setting policy experiment rather than a fully realised model of migrant integration.

BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

Following the adoption of NIAS, Moroccan authorities facilitated returnees' and migrants' access to healthcare, basic education, and certain social services, at least for those who had obtained regular status. Efforts were also made to issue residency documents and refugee or temporary protection cards to asylum seekers. The strategy created an institutional framework that enabled greater involvement of NGOs, municipalities, and international partners—including IOM, UNHCR, and the EU—in implementation, assistance programs, and capacity-building initiatives. The NIAS promoted a blend of human rights and humanitarian protection, integration, development, and improved governance, while also reflecting Morocco's European migration policy and African diplomacy, helping reposition the country as a leader in welcoming and respecting migrants' rights.

Implementation remained partial and uneven, both geographically and over time. Many migrants—particularly those who remained irregular—continued to face legal, economic, and social vulnerabilities. Some observers have noted that Morocco’s approach relied on periodic “exceptional” regularisation campaigns rather than steady, institutionalised pathways, raising questions about long-term sustainability. Persistent gaps also remained in labour-market integration, delays in establishing a fully operational national asylum system, and tensions between protection objectives and intensified EU-Morocco border- control cooperation.

KEY LESSONS

Migration policies should prioritise human dignity alongside security. Effective migration management requires balancing protection, inclusion, and rights with enforcement objectives. In Morocco, the NSIA set a precedent by openly framing migration governance around dignity, human rights, and social inclusion rather than solely focusing on border control and security.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Sustainable migration policies require shared ownership and multi-level cooperation. To strengthen long-term viability, migration strategies should actively involve local authorities and elected officials, be supported by stronger regional cooperation across neighbouring and origin countries and be accompanied by sustained engagement from international partners. In the Moroccan context, this translates into deeper local political ownership, enhanced Maghreb and African cooperation, and more consistent European involvement.

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